AI Interview Prep Roadmap

A practical checklist for engineers preparing for GenAI & Agentic AI interviews.

The 6-Layer Readiness Stack

L1 Foundations

- ▸ **Learn:** LLMs, tokens, context windows, embeddings, structured output, function calling
- ▸ **Practice:** explain an LLM app & when to use embeddings — simply
- × **Avoid:** reciting definitions without knowing when each applies

L2 Project Building

- ▸ **Build:** OpenAI SDK app, RAG app, support assistant, tool-calling & agentic workflow, FastAPI service
- ▸ **Each project has:** problem, I/O, API boundary, schema, model call, error handling, logging
- × **Avoid:** "I followed a tutorial" — a project you can't explain is just a folder

L3 Project Explanation

- ▸ **Practice:** problem → scope → architecture → model choice → data flow → trade-offs → limits → improvements
- × **Avoid:** "I used LangChain and a vector DB" — that's your imports, not your thinking

L4 System Design

- ▸ **Learn:** RAG vs agents vs fine-tuning, tool calling, orchestration, memory vs state, HITL, async, permissions
- ▸ **Anchor example:** support assistant — RAG for policy, tool for orders, HITL for refunds, evals for grounding + tool correctness
- × **Avoid:** opening with a framework name — architecture starts before the framework

L5 Evaluation & Reliability

- ▸ **Learn:** grounding, retrieval quality, faithfulness, tool selection + argument correctness, latency, cost, safety, observability
- ▸ **Practice:** how you'd *measure* it works — not vibes
- × **Avoid:** "it worked when I tested it" — once isn't controlled

L6 Interview Communication

- ▸ **Practice:** 60-second project answer, STAR, a system-design framework, senior add-ons
- × **Avoid:** memorized scripts — they collapse on the first follow-up. Learn structure, not lines.

7-Day Preparation Plan

DAY 1 Pick one project + write its problem statement

DAY 2 Draw the architecture (boxes & arrows)

DAY 3 List 3 trade-offs you made

DAY 4 List 5 ways it could fail

DAY 5 Define 3 eval metrics

DAY 6 Write the 60-second explanation

DAY 7 Practice aloud + handle follow-ups

Depth on one beats shallow on ten.

Next step — the articulation layer

This roadmap tells you **what** to prepare. The **Agentic AI Interview Playbook** trains **how to answer** — Agentic AI, RAG, system design, trade-off, failure-mode, and production-readiness questions with structure. If your gap is layer 6, start there.

→ learn.manifoldailearning.com/services/agentic-interview